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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: None

Coverage Date: 1900-1940

Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): C

Of the games in which the chief movement is done in a line or row, the so-called arch game is very common in East Africa. Among the Chaga two players form an arch with their raised arms. The other players, holding one another by the hand, rush through singing, 'Kindaviroe tree! And scar of burning! Kindaviroe tree!' The last of the row tries if possible to elude the grasp of the 'door-keepers', but is usually caught. When only one boy is left, he redeems the prisoners. Approaching the 'door-keepers' with a dracaena leaf, the sign which makes a request irresistible, he asks them to give him a child to fetch firewood, and then one to draw water and so on through all the domestic tasks.

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Other games are elaborations of hide-and-seek. In its simplest form it is played already with the toddler by the nurse. On the pasture children hide behind bushes, banana trees, or lie flat on the ground. The seeker makes jokes or grimaces to cause the hidden children to laugh. If he cannot find them, he may cut his finger as a magical coercion. The game is developed by older boys into a make-believe hunt. Some children scamper off, acting as bush bucks. The 'hunters' order some of the smaller boys to be their dogs and urge them on to search in the less accessible places. If one 'animal' is caught, he may be made to look after the cattle of the successful hunter for a whole day! In a similar game three concentric circles are formed. The inner one is said to represent  271 leopards enclosed by wart-hogs and wildebeeste. The 'leopards' attempt to break through the two outer rings. The losers of this game are made 'slaves' or servants of the winners.

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